

### Mother's dreams

As the competition came to an end, he wore a sheepish grin, seemingly embarrassed by the attention, even as his seasoned rivals congratulated him on his achievement. Watching from the stands, beaming with pride, was Jonathan's mother, Ancy.

She could take much of the credit for his introduction to the sport. Growing up in Bengaluru, Jonathan had been an energetic child. "He just had so much energy. I had him try everything — gymnastics, dance, skating, even chess," Ancy recalled.

She had even enrolled him in a few classes of *silambam*, the traditional Tamil stick-fighting martial art. "I thought he should stay connected to his culture," she added.

But what Ancy truly hoped for was that her son would take an interest in shooting. She had been a college-level rifle shooter during her time in the National Cadet Corps (NCC) and had once aspired to join the Air Force — an ambition that was thwarted by her family's disapproval.

"Although I eventually took up a corporate job, I was determined to stay connected to the defence sector in some way. I married my husband, who works in the Intelligence Bureau, and I wanted my children to one day join the armed forces as well. I felt shooting would be the first step towards that," she said.

In March 2022, she took Jonathan, then 13, and his younger brother to his first class at Bengaluru's Hawkeye Shooting Academy. While she usually lets Jonathan choose his own activities, she admits she was more insistent this time.

"I told him, 'You are going to take this class, and you are going to complete it. Don't even think about quitting.'"

"His younger brother was actually the more natural shooter, but at just eight years old, he was too young to compete — the minimum age for state-level competition in India is 10. Jonathan, however, was 13, so I was really hoping he would stick with it," she says.

He did. Coach K.Y. Sharandra at the Hawkeye Academy noticed Jonathan's passion immediately.

"He initially joined just for a foundation course, where students learn the basics of shooting. But I quickly realised that no matter how much I taught him, he just wanted to keep shooting more and more," Sharandra recalls.

When the coach cautiously increased Jonathan's training load, the youngster embraced it wholeheartedly.

Just three months after he started training, Jonathan competed in his first state-level competition, followed by his first nationals later

that year. Though he didn't win an individual medal, Sharandra saw something special in him. Convinced of his potential, he personally approached Jonathan's school principal to request support for the young shooter's training.

"I promised him — and I still believe it — that Jonathan will be competing at the 2028 Olympics," he says.

### Freestyle edge

Over the past year, Jonathan has been steadily pushing towards national recognition. He won a team gold at the Junior Nationals last year with a qualification score of 576, followed by a 582 at the Kumar Surendra Singh Shooting Championships.

He then posted a personal best of 587 at the 2024 Khelo India Games, where he won silver. He has recorded even higher qualification scores in practice, twice achieving 594. However, he knows there is still more to be done.

"I need to do it 10 times more in practice, and then perhaps I can shoot this in competition," he says.

His coach believes it is only a matter of time. According to him, Jonathan is a natural shooter. "There are shooters who follow a very precise routine every time they take a shot. Then there are freestyle shooters. Yusuf Dikec, the viral gold-medal-winning Turkish shooter from the 2024 Olympics, is that kind. Jonathan is similar. He just has to align the target with the sight and pull the trigger. He is very uncomplicated," says Sharandra.

Jonathan echoes this sentiment. "It's not difficult for me. I like shooting. I love hitting the bullseye the most," he says.

Despite winning gold at the National Games, Jonathan knows that shooting is becoming an increasingly competitive sport in India. In a few weeks, he will compete in the shooting trials in New Delhi, which will determine selection for the Indian squad for the upcoming World Cups. In his case, these trials will decide whether he secures a place in the Indian team for the Junior World Cup in September.

However, he is less concerned about the trials themselves and more about the challenges surrounding them. "My Class 10 board exams start on the 15th. I will write my first paper and then travel to Delhi for my trials. This month is going to be very tough for me," he says.

With both academics and sport being equally important, he will need to manage his time carefully. "I have to study, and I have to train. I won't have any time for cartoons this time," he adds with a smile.